OTT

The Power of Imagination

Black, White & Gray—Love Kills is an innovative new **crime series** on Sony LIV

An intelligent filmmaker knows that all stories have been told already, and a fresh story means fresh storytelling. Case in point: the new Sony LIV Hindi series ***Black, White & Gray—Love Kills.*** Written, directed and edited by Pushkar Sunil Mahabal, the ***Rashomon***-like six-episode series is part true crime mockumentary, part chase thriller, and full metafiction. What could have been a straightforward crime story is explored as a fake documentary looking into the aftermath of the crime, juxtaposed with its dramatic re-enactment. This style coaxes us to question the ethics of the true crime genre, and the intersections of caste, class and gender across which crimes occur.

A politician's daughter and the son of the politician's driver sneak out one night to have sex in a hotel. Later, CCTV footage suggests that the man has killed the woman and escaped with her body. The police allege that the man goes on to murder a cop and two others in his killing spree. The man has been absconding for two years.

The series is framed as a project by a western filmmaker visiting India. His mockumentary features interviews with friends and relatives of the victims, while the dramatic re-enactment shows what could have gone down between the man, the woman, and the three other victims. The filmmaker reveals his trump card at the end of episode one: he has tracked down and interviewed the accused.

One of the most innovative Indian series in a long time, ***Black, White & Gray...*** is true gonzo filmmaking. At a time of despair in the Mumbai film industry over its products' staleness and commercial failures, Mahabal proves that imagination is all it takes. ■

—Devarsi Ghosh

It's a follow-up to Mahabal's first film, ***Welcome Home***, a thriller he made on a shoestring budget



A FICTIONAL TRUE CRIME The series is framed as a project by a western filmmaker visiting India



A TRIBUTE The festival features a retrospective of the late Shyam Benegal's films

MILIND SHELTE

FILM FESTIVAL

FOR THE LOVE OF CINEMA

Here's what you can expect at this year's **Habitat Film Festival** in Delhi

The 17th edition of the Habitat Film Festival (HFF), scheduled in Delhi from May 16-25, will be a celebration of Indian cinema's past, present and future. Since its inception two decades ago, the platform has been a breath of fresh air for independent filmmakers, regional auteurs and cinephiles who seek an exceptional cinematic experience. From tributes to cinematic legends to a curated selection of contemporary films across 24 languages, HFF 2025 promises a packed programme. One of the highlights is a tribute to the titan of Indian parallel cinema, Shyam Benegal. The retrospective will kick off with a screening of his first film *Ankur*, in the presence of actress Shabana Azmi, who made her cinematic debut with it. "To complement the retrospective, we're also presenting an exhibition that traces his remarkable journey," says Vidyun Singh, Creative Head Programmes, Habitat World, India Habitat Centre. A thoughtfully curated celebration of Raj Kapoor's birth centenary is also on the cards, and includes a *dastangoi* performance, poster exhibition and the screening of *Awaara* along with a documentary by Siddharth Kak. "We are also screening award-winning films from across India, like *All We Imagine As Light*, *Pyre* and *Feminichi Fathima*, besides a powerful line-up of feminist documentaries and a special package of non-fiction films," adds Singh. ■

—Geetika Sachdev